

1261–65



This example of Mamluk architecture from the height of the sultanate adorns the entrance to the mausoleum of Qalawun in Cairo, Egypt.

ITALIAN NOBLEMAN AND LATER DOMINICAN MONK, THOMAS AQUINAS (1225–74) became one of the most important philosophers in the history of Western thought.

Renowned for his work in **uniting faith and reason**, Aquinas's period of greatest productivity occurred between 1258 and 1273, when he penned his two best-known works, the *Summa contra Gentiles* and the *Summa Theologiae*.

In 1261, Michael VIII Paleologus (r. 1259–61), the Byzantine emperor of Nicaea, concluded the **Treaty of Nymphaeum** with the Genoese, agreeing to cede them all the trading privileges once enjoyed by the Venetians (see 981–990). He had already secured an alliance with the Bulgarians, and was now poised to achieve his dream of re-taking Constantinople from the **Latin Empire** (Constantinople and environs, captured during the fourth crusade), and reconstituting the Byzantine Greek Empire. In July 1261, a Byzantine army took advantage of the absence of the Venetian fleet to cross the Bosphorus strait and take Constantinople. The Latin emperor, Baldwin II fled, and the **Paleologus Empire** was established.

Thomas Aquinas

This 15th-century altarpiece depicts Thomas Aquinas, whose philosophy still underpins Catholic dogma.



Paleologus would campaign tirelessly to restore lost Byzantine lands.

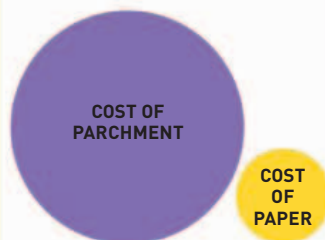
The **Second Baron's War** in England between 1264 and 1267 was brought about by a combination of newly kindled national consciousness and resentment at foreign interference. **Henry III** of England (r. 1216–72) had introduced many foreign officers into government and taxed the English heavily to fund overseas adventures and papal extortion. Rebels led by **Simon de Montfort**, Earl of Leicester, captured the king at Lewes in 1265 and summoned the first European parliament that included elected representatives.

Meanwhile, the **Mamluks** began a push to rid the Holy Land of the Crusader kingdoms once and for all.

1266–71



Geneta Mariam church in Ethiopia, built during the Solomonid era.



Cost of paper versus parchment
After paper-making technology was introduced to Italy, the cost of vegetable-based paper fell to 1/6 of the cost of animal-based parchment.

THE SOLOMONID DYNASTY IN ETHIOPIA

was founded in 1270 by Yekuno Amlak, displacing the previous Zagwe dynasty, and claiming to have restored the legitimate line of the ancient Christian kings of Aksum. Amlak claimed descent from the biblical Solomon, via the possibly Ethiopian Queen of Sheba.

The town of **Fabriano** in Italy lies close to the Adriatic port of Ancona, which was notable in the 13th century for trade with the Muslim world. This is probably how paper manufacture became established there in the 1270s. Use of animal gelatin in place of more degradable vegetable gel made Fabriano paper more durable, and the town became the principal paper manufacturing site in Europe.

In 1270, Louis IX of France made another attempt at crusading, but on the request of Charles of Anjou, the **Eighth Crusade** was diverted to Tunis, where disease killed Louis and his army.

1272–75



Former stronghold of the Knights Hospitaller, Krak des Chevaliers or “fortress of the knights” in Syria was taken by the Mamluks and fortified further.



Travels of Marco Polo

To reach China, Marco Polo traveled through Anatolia, Iran, and Afghanistan. On his return, he sailed to Hormuz in Persia via Sumatra.

IN 1271, THE VENETIAN MERCHANT AND EXPLORER, MARCO POLO

(c. 1254–1324), traveled to China. Arriving at Kublai Khan's court in 1275, the Great Khan employed Marco Polo in various capacities. In 1292, he escorted a Mongol princess to Persia, returning to Italy three years later and writing a **travel memoir** while a prisoner of the Genoese. Polo's memoir, *The Travels*—known by Italians as *Il Milione*, because of the belief that it contains a million lies—is a fascinating portrait of the Mongolian Empire at its height. The *Pax Mongolica* (see 1236–40) allowed freedom of movement through lands under the authority of **Il-khanate**, and it was said that a virgin with a pot of gold on her head could pass unmolested from Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul) to Beijing.

In 1272, **Edward Plantagenet** (r. 1272–1307), heir apparent to the English throne, returned from

the **Holy Land**, having forced the **Mamluks** to conclude a 10-year truce in his attempts to destroy Acre, one of the last remaining Crusader footholds in Outremer. The Mamluks had already taken the apparently impregnable **Krak des Chevaliers** from the Knights Hospitaller in 1271.

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PERCENT
THE WORLD
LAND AREA
COVERED BY
THE MONGOL
EMPIRE AT ITS
HEIGHT

